

Mak Trnka

TA Tan Zhao

POL S 328: International Organizations

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MEMO for UN Security Council (UNSC)

To: President of United Nations (UN) Security Council

RE: Proposed Changes to Voting Practices

Excellency,

I wish to inform you of the proposal for the UN Nations Security Council reform pertaining to the voting practices considering the long-standing criticism related to the UN Security Council membership and decision-making rules that govern current voting practices.

One of the biggest complaints about the UN Security Council is that there is too much inequality that comes into play between the permanent and non-permanent seats in the UN Security Council, which leads to its inefficiency. This is a serious concern, especially in times like these when the world's peace is at stake, given that the SC's primary responsibility is international peace maintenance. When we talk about how much power each member has, a former UN ambassador to Singapore from 2001-2002 Kishore Mahbubani stated, "Fortunately, just before I served on the Council, a Chilean diplomat alerted me that while in theory, the body has fifteen members (five permanent members and ten elected), in practice it has five members and ten observers. This was a profound insight. The P5 almost totally dominates and run the Council. This is why the composition of the permanent members matters so much: if they do not

reflect the great powers of today, the Council will increasingly make flawed decisions, as it has begun to do.” (Sebastian 2016: pg. 158). Furthermore, the main reason there is a difference in power between the permanent and non-permanent members is that one of them has the right to veto.

The UNSC has five permanent members (P5) which are Britain, France, United States, Russia, and China, while on the other hand, it has ten non-permanent members which Estonia, India, Ireland, Kenya, Mexico, Niger, Norway, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines, Tunisia, and Vietnam. Unlike the P5, none of the non-permanent members have the right to veto.

Furthermore, since the P5 has the right to veto, they have the absolute power to prevent any action a majority of UN Security Council members want. Therefore, the veto power under the UN has been criticized as far too democratic and as one of the main factors why the UN lacks the ability to prevent any of the inhumane actions being attempted by the P5 members or others. For example, several US moves to help Israel, such as moving the US embassy to Jerusalem, have been condemned by a resolution a majority of the UN Security Council member’s support. However, despite the majority, since the US is one of the P5, it successfully vetoed any of those resolutions condemning their actions with Israel, which successfully allows them, without being prevented, to do whatever they want with Israel. Also, most UN Security Council members have supported a resolution condemning Russia’s decision to annex Crimea. However, since Russia is also part of the P5, which gave them the power to veto that resolution, the UN had no power to prevent Russia from annexing Crimea despite the majority supporting it. Lastly, China has been strongly criticized for its Uighur Concentration Camps, and a majority of UN Security Council members supported a resolution that would prevent China from continuing its concentration

camps. However, as one of the P5 members, China had the power to veto any such resolution that would've stopped them from continuing their concentration camps.

Due to the inequality between the UN Security Council members, making the voting process so undemocratic by letting the five permanent members have the power to veto anything the majority wants, the UN Security Council should reform the way voting works. k. When the members vote, it should be run the similar way voting works in the US government. In that sense, the P5, which are Britain, France, United States, Russia, and China, would all have the same power as the US President and congress voting, while the non-permanent members would only have the same power as congress. For example, the P5 would still have the ability to vote and veto what a majority wants, but, like US congress, the non-permanent members, including any of the P5 members who didn't veto, still would have the power to override any veto one or all P5 member did if a two-thirds majority, which would be a total of ten members, agree with whatever resolution comes to the floor. Moreover, if one or all P5 members veto and less than ten or two-thirds of the majority votes yes on a resolution, the resolution wouldn't pass.

Therefore, if the UN Security Council decides to implement this method of voting, where still only the P5 have the power to veto but a two-thirds majority can override that, this would make the voting system far more democratic because the non-permanent members would not just have to be the observers, but also be an essential part of deciding what resolution should pass, not giving 100% power to only the P5. For example, if the US wanted to recognize a part of the middle east as a part of Israel, but it considered a national security concern and the UN Security Council wants to pass a resolution that would prevent it, ten or more of the members would have to support the resolution to override US's veto which would then prevent the area being part of Israel.

However, there could still be specific barriers with a voting system like the proposed one. If we make the non-permanent members have the power to override a veto with two-thirds of the majority, that might make few of the P5 members, especially the US, actually think of leaving or even make the UN more likely collapse. That's because the US and other powers, as critical they've been about the UN, decided to stay because they find the Veto power too useful of a way to allow any of their foreign policy interests to happen. Also, it's been rumored that if the League of Nations gave certain members the power to veto, it could've lasted longer. For example, former UN ambassador to Singapore from 2001-2002 Kishore Mahbubani also stated, "The main reason why the UN has survived for seven decades and why the League of Nations collapsed after less than three decades is that the UN, unlike the League, gave the great powers a vested interest in keeping it alive through the privilege of the veto. And even though the US government has frequently criticized and even occasionally demonized the UN, it has never threatened to leave it. The veto is too valuable an asset to give up easily." (Sebastian 2016: pg. 158-159).

References:

Einsiedel, Sebastian von, et al. *The UN Security Council in the Twenty-First Century*. Lynne Rienner Publishers, 2016.